Play-Based Early Childhood Curriculum

Birth through age six | An original curriculum for childcare centers

Purpose

Support secure relationships, communication, movement, thinking, curiosity, creativity and belonging through meaningful play and everyday care. Plan environments and invitations that respond to real children instead of requiring every child to produce the same result.

How the curriculum is organized

Seven developmental pathways; seven connected learning areas; eight kinds of play spaces; a responsive adult teaching cycle; sample five-day menus for each pathway; a flexible annual connection map; and practical observation and planning forms. The companion activity library contains 98 original invitations.

Age scope

Birth–5 months; 6–11 months; 12–23 months; 24–35 months; 3-year-olds; 4-year-olds; and 5- and 6-year-olds through 83 months. These ranges organize choices; they are not milestones, diagnostic categories, grades or deadlines.

A professional working draft

This is independently written educational material, not an endorsed commercial curriculum or a validated developmental assessment. Review actual health procedures, individual plans, access and local requirements before implementation. The companion research report preserves the earlier source-access limitations; this guide makes no verified popularity or standards-alignment claim.

What play-based teaching means

Play is meaningful activity in which children have real agency: they can act on an idea, choose a response, repeat, change direction and communicate their own meaning. For infants, a warm back-and-forth exchange and voluntary movement are early play. Older children may pretend, construct, investigate, make art or create games.

Teaching move	What the adult does	What stays with the child
Child-led play	Prepare a safe accessible environment; watch; respond when useful.	The idea, material use and direction within safe limits.
Guided play	Hold a learning purpose and offer a useful material, word, question or demonstration.	Meaningful choices, strategies and ways to respond.
Brief explicit teaching	Show a needed skill clearly, such as safe scissor use or a taught sound-spelling pattern.	A real opportunity to apply it in play, reading, writing or a project.
Care and connection	Respond to needs and include understandable communication and appropriate participation.	Dignity, comfort, a readable routine and access to support.

Guidance is purposeful support, not an adult script disguised as choice. A craft with one required product, constant quizzing, compulsory rotations or a worksheet sequence is not the core of this curriculum. Rules protecting safety, consent and other people’s work remain the adult’s responsibility.

Helping a child feel safe and settle with a responsive adult is often called co-regulation. It is expected support, not a failure of independence.

Seven learning areas in real play

Area	Example inside play	Useful evidence
Relationships & regulation	Two children negotiate space for their buildings with adult support.	The request, boundary, support and actual result.
Communication & early literacy	A child dictates a sign or reads a suitable message for a pretend shop.	What the message means, communication used and help needed.
Movement & self-care	An infant reaches comfortably; an older child uses an adapted tool.	Voluntary movement, access, comfort and support.
Thinking & mathematics	Children compare bridge spans or match one cup to each person.	The strategy and the real comparison, not only a correct number.
Science & inquiry	A child changes a ramp surface and compares what happens.	Prediction, actual result, changed condition and uncertainty.
Creative expression	A child revises a drawing or invents a sound for a story.	Choices and the child’s own intended meaning.
Community & belonging	Children incorporate a family’s chosen language or routine into play.	Respectful participation and whose perspective is included.

Interest, attention, persistence, flexibility, communication and help seeking run through all areas. One play episode can support several areas. Do not interrupt it merely to collect a separate piece of evidence for every domain.

Prepare spaces, not compulsory stations

Play space	Materials and possibilities	Adult preparation
Connection and quiet	Familiar books, comfortable supported access, a responsive adult.	Keep comfort available; quiet is a choice, not exclusion.
Construction and spatial play	Safe age-appropriate blocks, open space and optional representation tools.	Check stability, size and accessibility; preserve work when practical.
Pretend and community play	Diverse dolls and props reflecting real lives and children’s ideas.	Avoid stereotypes and small parts in younger-child areas.
Books, stories and messages	Home-language books, suitable texts and accessible mark-making tools.	Include oral storytelling, signs, dictation and augmentative communication.
Art and making	Safe media, adapted tools, storage for unfinished work.	Show safe use without supplying an identical finished product.
Music and movement	Comfortable sound choices and clear accessible space.	Offer quiet/visual roles; participation and performance are optional.
Nature and outdoor inquiry	Safe accessible places and adult-selected observation materials.	Review weather, surfaces, plants, animals and boundaries.
Sensory comparison and investigation	One or a few safe materials suited to actual sensory and mouthing needs.	No forced touch/tasting; water and tools need approved direct supervision.

These are possible experiences, not eight centers that every child must visit. Infant/toddler spaces use developmentally safe materials and individual care rhythms. Older children’s tools and small materials must not be accessible to younger children.

Young infants · Birth–5 months

Play begins in a relationship

An infant’s looking, turning, moving, sounding, resting and responding are meaningful participation. Warm exchanges and comfortable awake movement are the curriculum. A baby does not need an academic lesson or a group activity.

Prepare

Provide a familiar responsive adult, a clear safe floor space, a sturdy adult-held book and one comfortable sensory invitation at a time. Keep all play materials separate from the approved sleep space.

Join the play

Wait for a cue; respond gently; pause. If the infant turns away, stiffens, becomes distressed or needs care, change the interaction or stop. Never use withholding comfort or care to create a learning opportunity.

Learning area	Possibilities to support
Relationships & regulation	Feel safe with a familiar adult who responds to cues.
Communication & early literacy	Experience back-and-forth sounds, expressions and home-language words.
Movement & self-care	Choose comfortable voluntary movement with safe support.
Thinking & mathematics	Notice a repeated social action and its response.
Science & inquiry	Explore a safe visual or touch difference without forced contact.
Creative expression	Share rhythm, movement or a simple picture with a responsive adult.
Community & belonging	Connect familiar voices, names and routines across home and care.

Illustrative note: “Infant turned away after a sound. Adult paused. Infant relaxed and looked back.” This records an exchange; it does not score attention. Next invitation: Revisit the same comfortable exchange. Familiarity and a well-timed pause can be a richer next step than adding another toy.

Older infants · 6–11 months

Explore, connect and repeat

Older infants often learn through reaching, moving, filling, emptying, making a sound and returning to a trusted adult. Follow the child’s actual movement and communication; do not make crawling, walking or speech a condition of participation.

Prepare

Offer clear accessible floor space, a low stable open container, large inspected infant-safe objects and a familiar book. Keep a responsive adult nearby.

Join the play

Notice what the child is trying to do. Offer only as much help as needed, describe the real action and wait. The adult remains a secure base and responds promptly to needs.

Learning area	Possibilities to support
Relationships & regulation	Explore with a trusted adult available for comfort and connection.
Communication & early literacy	Share attention and meanings through gestures, sounds and words.
Movement & self-care	Reach, release or travel in the child’s own safe way.
Thinking & mathematics	Explore in/out, action/result and partly hidden objects.
Science & inquiry	Notice surfaces and movement through safe voluntary exploration.
Creative expression	Express choices through sound, music response and movement.
Community & belonging	Communicate preferences that a caregiver recognizes and respects.

Illustrative note: “Put a large object in the container, tipped it out and repeated three times. Adult steadied the container once.” Next invitation: Change only one useful feature, such as a wider opening. Do not make success harder just because the child repeated the work.

Young toddlers · 12–23 months

Everyday actions become play

Young toddlers explore what objects do, repeat useful actions and begin to represent familiar routines. Warm language, movement and predictable care support their play. Parallel interests do not require forced sharing.

Prepare

Offer large light blocks, open containers, safe push materials, simple pretend-care props, books and a secure place for belongings. Arrange a small number of accessible choices.

Join the play

Join briefly, name the action and give processing time. Model one useful action, such as wiping or placing a block, then let the child decide how to continue.

Learning area	Possibilities to support
Relationships & regulation	Use adult support during transitions and strong feelings.
Communication & early literacy	Communicate a message and experience a meaningful response.
Movement & self-care	Move safely and participate in a small care action with help.
Thinking & mathematics	Explore filling, emptying, balance and practical comparisons.
Science & inquiry	Notice a familiar natural feature or a rolling object’s movement.
Creative expression	Choose marks, sounds and movement without a required product.
Community & belonging	Represent familiar people and routines in varied respectful ways.

Illustrative note: “Moved blocks into a bowl, then used it to carry them to the mat. Said ‘more’ and pointed.” Next invitation: Offer another safe container or a useful word in the child’s home language. Follow the child’s carrying idea rather than redirecting to a sorting task.

Older toddlers · 24–35 months

Ideas, pretend routines and nearby peers

Older toddlers may sustain pretend actions, use more symbolic communication and become increasingly interested in peers. Development varies. Provide enough materials and adult support so play does not depend on winning, waiting too long or sharing before ready.

Prepare

Provide parallel sets of popular materials, open-ended blocks, safe pretend props, drawing tools and an accessible movement route. Offer a quieter choice as part of the room, not as a punishment.

Join the play

Describe what each child is doing. Help with a short request, a boundary or an alternative. Protect people and work; do not require a child to solve unsafe behavior alone.

Learning area	Possibilities to support
Relationships & regulation	Practice being near peers and receiving help with transitions.
Communication & early literacy	Tell, act or gesture about a play event or familiar story.
Movement & self-care	Use an accessible route and participate in hygiene with help.
Thinking & mathematics	Match useful objects, count a small real collection or sort by a chosen feature.
Science & inquiry	Notice what changes when a safe path or condition changes.
Creative expression	Make original marks and invent a movement or sound.
Community & belonging	Explore different homes and contribute to care of shared space.

Illustrative note: “Two children built beside each other. One asked for a block with a modeled phrase; the other offered a different block.” Next invitation: Keep duplicate materials available. Invite a shared action only when both children want it; playing alongside is valuable.

Preschool · 3 years · 36–47 months

Pretend, build, tell and investigate

Three-year-olds can explore meaningful ideas through construction, pretend play, stories, movement and art. Their chosen play creates reasons to use language, number and problem solving. Avoid turning every action into an adult question.

Prepare

Prepare construction, pretend-play, book/message, art and outdoor choices. Keep familiar materials available long enough for play ideas to develop. Make room for individual and shared work.

Join the play

Observe first. Join with a relevant comment or action, then offer a word, question or material only when it helps the child’s purpose. Support joining play and disagreements without taking over the whole story.

Learning area	Possibilities to support
Relationships & regulation	Explore respectful play entry and supported solutions to small problems.
Communication & early literacy	Talk about stories and notice useful names, sounds and signs.
Movement & self-care	Coordinate tools and movement with access and safety support.
Thinking & mathematics	Use quantity, shape and spatial ideas for a practical purpose.
Science & inquiry	Observe light, plants and other real changes, separating guesses from facts.
Creative expression	Communicate an original idea through art, sound or movement.
Community & belonging	Connect shared agreements and family knowledge with classroom life.

Illustrative note: “Built a wall around the animals, then moved two blocks to make an entrance. Adult supplied the word ‘gate’.”
Next invitation: Offer paper for a sign or a wider block for the gate. Let the child decide whether the play needs either.

Pre-K · 4 years · 48–59 months

Plan, compare, represent and revise

Four-year-olds can revisit play across sessions, negotiate roles, represent ideas and use more deliberate strategies. Intentional small-group teaching can support a specific need inside this larger play-rich day.

Prepare

Preserve work in progress when practical. Provide materials for construction, dramatic play, books, meaningful writing, pattern/quantity exploration, art and outdoor inquiry. Include visual plans and adapted tools.

Join the play

Listen for a real problem. Model a needed tool or strategy briefly, then return the decision to the child. Ask a genuine question with more than one plausible response, rather than quizzing to a predetermined answer.

Learning area	Possibilities to support
Relationships & regulation	Negotiate roles and find an individually useful regulation support.
Communication & early literacy	Play with spoken sounds and make a message for a real audience.
Movement & self-care	Use a safe preparation sequence or design an accessible movement game.
Thinking & mathematics	Compare quantities and describe a repeating unit or pattern.
Science & inquiry	Test one safe change and record what was actually observed.
Creative expression	Develop a construction or shared expressive idea and revise it.
Community & belonging	Represent a familiar place and evaluate a helpful contribution.

Illustrative note: “Changed the bridge after the wide vehicle would not fit. Measured the opening with two blocks and tried again.” Next invitation: Offer an alternate measuring unit or invite a drawing that shows the change. Do not replace the child’s design with an adult model.

Kindergarten bridge · 5- and 6-year-olds · 60–83 months

Use play for purposeful inquiry and learning tools

Five- and six-year-olds can combine sustained play, design, storytelling and projects with accessible explicit teaching. Coordinate reading, mathematics and transitions with the receiving school. Play does not remove the need to teach a useful skill clearly.

Prepare

Provide books and checked decodable texts, writing/representation tools, construction and measurement materials, creative media and a space to revisit questions. Keep movement, relationships, care and rest/quiet options in the day.

Join the play

Choose a real purpose with the child. Teach a needed tool, such as a known sound-spelling pattern or measurement strategy, and use it in meaningful work. Help the child explain, check and revise without timed performance pressure.

Learning area	Possibilities to support
Relationships & regulation	Collaborate, consider perspectives and revise a workable plan.
Communication & early literacy	Read a suitable message and communicate a finding through writing, dictation or another accessible form.
Movement & self-care	Carry out a safe practical project and identify helpful transition supports.
Thinking & mathematics	Represent joining/separating and measure for a real design purpose.
Science & inquiry	Compare conditions, evidence and models without pretending a small test proves everything.
Creative expression	Sustain an original expressive work and choose how to share it.
Community & belonging	Include family knowledge and the child’s voice in decisions and transitions.

Illustrative note: “Used equal blocks to measure the span, wrote ‘6’ on the plan with support, and explained that the next design needed one more block.” Next invitation: Offer a related design problem, a suitable text or an audience question. Keep the child’s purpose visible and the required support available.

A day with room for play

Pathway	A flexible daily rhythm
Infants	Arrival and connection → individual care/comfort/rest → brief comfortable awake exchange or safe floor exploration → respond to needs and repeat. No required group learning timetable.
Toddlers	Familiar arrival → movement and concrete play → care/food as needed → outdoor access → rest/quiet → more familiar play and supported departure. Allow flexible transitions.
Preschool / Pre-K	Arrival choices → sustained self-chosen play with brief useful invitations → outdoor movement → food/care → rest/quiet options → a second play/project opportunity → optional reflection and departure.
5- and 6-year-olds	Keep sustained play and projects, movement, care and relationships. Include appropriate explicit literacy/math teaching and authentic application; coordinate with school expectations and individual access.

Protect continuity

A preschool group might have a substantial play block of roughly 60–90 minutes when practical, while children move among accessible choices. This is an example organizational choice, not a developmental requirement or a rule that every child stay at one activity. Infants and toddlers follow cues rather than this timetable.

Care is not an interruption

Feeding, sleep, toileting, comfort, hygiene and health needs take priority over an activity. Use current approved procedures and individual plans. Awake tummy-time play is directly supervised and separate from safe sleep; toys and loose play materials do not belong in a sleep space.

How an adult extends play

First notice…	A useful response…	Then wait for…
A repeated action	“You tried that again.” Leave the material available.	Whether the child repeats, changes or communicates a need.
A real obstacle	Offer a relevant word, model or accessible tool.	The child’s chosen strategy, including asking for help.
A developing idea	“Tell or show me what you are making.”	The child’s meaning rather than the adult’s guess.
A comparison	“What is different? How could we check?”	A strategy, gesture, test or another question.
A peer problem	Ensure safety; describe the event; support a request or workable boundary.	Whether the proposed solution actually helps.
Fatigue, distress or withdrawal	Pause, offer care/support, simplify or end the invitation.	Comfort and a real choice about continuing.

Use fewer questions when a comment or quiet attention would help. Do not require a child to explain everything they do. Avoid praise that ranks children or turns a product into proof of intelligence. Name the real action: “You changed the base and checked whether it stood.”

Step in immediately for harm, unsafe tools, exclusion or safeguarding concerns. Stepping back never means leaving children without supervision or needed support.

Plan from a real observation

1. Write the event

“The child put three blocks across the opening. The wide vehicle did not fit. They moved two blocks and tried again.” Keep this separate from an interpretation such as “is interested in bridges.”

2. Choose one useful purpose

Support comparing the opening with the vehicle, communicating a design or using a stable base. Do not add many objectives simply because the episode could connect with several domains.

3. Prepare a possible extension

Keep familiar blocks available. Offer a wider piece, an accessible measuring unit, paper for a sign or a photo of an appropriate structure. Ask whether the child wants any of it.

4. Follow the result

The child might measure, tell a story, change the purpose or decline. Record what happened and the adult support. The plan was a possibility; it is not a failed lesson when the child chooses another direction.

5. Revisit

Return to the interest on another day if it remains meaningful. Hear the family’s perspective and preserve the child’s own account. A new material is not automatically a better next step than repeated familiar play.

Annual connections · menu 1–6

Use these as optional connections to children’s interests. Start anywhere, repeat, pause or replace a connection. Do not turn them into a fixed monthly theme schedule, especially for infants.

Connection	Possible starting question	Possible extension
1. Belonging and routines	Who is here and how do we connect?	How do we care for shared spaces?
2. Bodies, movement and care	What can our bodies do comfortably?	What care and support do we need?
3. People, families and communication	How do people communicate?	How can we ask, listen and respond?
4. Light, shadow and sound	What do we notice about light?	What makes a sound, and who can access it?
5. Water, weather and change	What changes can we observe?	What does the weather mean for our care?
6. Living things	What do living things need?	How do we care for a plant or place?

The companion map offers four planning slots per connection: notice; revisit and model a useful strategy; extend a real question; review evidence and choose what comes next. Forty-eight slots leave four weeks in a 52-week calendar flexible for closures, transitions, repetition and local priorities.

Infant/toddler use is concrete and responsive: a familiar voice, a safe material, care participation or outdoor noticing. They do not need to understand or perform the abstract connection question.

Annual connections · menu 7–12

Use these as optional connections to children’s interests. Start anywhere, repeat, pause or replace a connection. Do not turn them into a fixed monthly theme schedule, especially for infants.

Connection	Possible starting question	Possible extension
7. Materials and making	What can this material do?	What happens when we change one feature?
8. Buildings and journeys	How do people and things move?	How can we describe a route?
9. Patterns, shapes and quantities	What repeats or fits together?	How many or how much is useful here?
10. Stories, signs and messages	What story do we want to tell?	Who is our audience?
11. Food, gardens and community	How do people care for a shared need?	How do choices reflect different families?
12. Reflection and transitions	What have we returned to?	Which supports should travel with us?

The companion map offers four planning slots per connection: notice; revisit and model a useful strategy; extend a real question; review evidence and choose what comes next. Forty-eight slots leave four weeks in a 52-week calendar flexible for closures, transitions, repetition and local priorities.

Infant/toddler use is concrete and responsive: a familiar voice, a safe material, care participation or outdoor noticing. They do not need to understand or perform the abstract connection question.

A week of responsive infant interaction

Young infants · Birth–5 months

This is an illustrative menu of possible invitations, not five compulsory daily lessons. Repeat familiar work, omit unsuitable ideas and change the plan after observing. Every day still includes responsive care, movement, communication, relationships and choice.

Day	Library IDs	Possible invitation
Monday	C001, C003	Notice cues and offer a brief face-to-face exchange.
Tuesday	C001, C005	Repeat a familiar exchange; offer comfortable supervised awake movement if available.
Wednesday	C004, C010	Use a family phrase or one voluntary adult-held texture exploration.
Thursday	C003, C007	Revisit a preferred exchange or a slow comfortable visual movement.
Friday	C002, C014	Review comfort cues and share a factual strength with the family.

What the educator prepares

Check the linked activity’s materials, safety, care needs and access. Keep familiar choices available and confirm that the purpose connects with a real interest. For infants, an invitation happens only during a comfortable awake opportunity; care and rest determine the day.

What to record

One actual action or communication; the adult support; the child’s response; and a possible next opportunity. Do not record an offered invitation as a completed skill.

How the week can change

Continue a worthwhile idea across several days. A child may choose another activity or another way to participate. Review the family’s perspective and what helped access before adding difficulty.

A week of familiar exploration

Older infants · 6–11 months

This is an illustrative menu of possible invitations, not five compulsory daily lessons. Repeat familiar work, omit unsuitable ideas and change the plan after observing. Every day still includes responsive care, movement, communication, relationships and choice.

Day	Library IDs	Possible invitation
Monday	C015, C017	Explore near a familiar adult; name what the infant notices.
Tuesday	C019, C020	Offer an achievable movement route and a large-object container.
Wednesday	C021, C023	Follow interest in a partly hidden object or a comfortable surface.
Thursday	C025, C026	Echo a sound and revisit a familiar song with optional movement.
Friday	C027, C028	Honor a choice and share familiar people/words from home.

What the educator prepares

Check the linked activity’s materials, safety, care needs and access. Keep familiar choices available and confirm that the purpose connects with a real interest. For infants, an invitation happens only during a comfortable awake opportunity; care and rest determine the day.

What to record

One actual action or communication; the adult support; the child’s response; and a possible next opportunity. Do not record an offered invitation as a completed skill.

How the week can change

Continue a worthwhile idea across several days. A child may choose another activity or another way to participate. Review the family’s perspective and what helped access before adding difficulty.

A week of useful everyday play

Young toddlers · 12–23 months

This is an illustrative menu of possible invitations, not five compulsory daily lessons. Repeat familiar work, omit unsuitable ideas and change the plan after observing. Every day still includes responsive care, movement, communication, relationships and choice.

Day	Library IDs	Possible invitation
Monday	C029, C031	Use a familiar arrival and back-and-forth play conversation.
Tuesday	C033, C034	Offer safe push/stop movement and supported care of a small spill.
Wednesday	C035, C036	Keep containers and blocks available for repeated ideas.
Thursday	C037, C039	Notice a safe outdoor feature and offer original mark making.
Friday	C041, C042	Revisit familiar belongings and pretend-care ideas with family words.

What the educator prepares

Check the linked activity’s materials, safety, care needs and access. Keep familiar choices available and confirm that the purpose connects with a real interest. For infants, an invitation happens only during a comfortable awake opportunity; care and rest determine the day.

What to record

One actual action or communication; the adult support; the child’s response; and a possible next opportunity. Do not record an offered invitation as a completed skill.

How the week can change

Continue a worthwhile idea across several days. A child may choose another activity or another way to participate. Review the family’s perspective and what helped access before adding difficulty.

A week of nearby peers and pretend ideas

Older toddlers · 24–35 months

This is an illustrative menu of possible invitations, not five compulsory daily lessons. Repeat familiar work, omit unsuitable ideas and change the plan after observing. Every day still includes responsive care, movement, communication, relationships and choice.

Day	Library IDs	Possible invitation
Monday	C043, C045	Provide parallel materials and follow each child’s play message.
Tuesday	C047, C049	Offer an accessible movement path and a useful small collection.
Wednesday	C052, C046	Follow a rolling-path question or a child-chosen familiar story.
Thursday	C053, C054	Offer tool choices for painting and invented movement.
Friday	C055, C056	Hear different home ideas and choose a real room-care contribution.

What the educator prepares

Check the linked activity’s materials, safety, care needs and access. Keep familiar choices available and confirm that the purpose connects with a real interest. For infants, an invitation happens only during a comfortable awake opportunity; care and rest determine the day.

What to record

One actual action or communication; the adult support; the child’s response; and a possible next opportunity. Do not record an offered invitation as a completed skill.

How the week can change

Continue a worthwhile idea across several days. A child may choose another activity or another way to participate. Review the family’s perspective and what helped access before adding difficulty.

A week following a place children build

Preschool · 3 years · 36–47 months

This is an illustrative menu of possible invitations, not five compulsory daily lessons. Repeat familiar work, omit unsuitable ideas and change the plan after observing. Every day still includes responsive care, movement, communication, relationships and choice.

Day	Library IDs	Possible invitation
Monday	C064, C059	Build a child-chosen place and share a relevant picture book.
Tuesday	C060, C063	Offer a useful sign or a real quantity problem if play calls for it.
Wednesday	C065, C066	Notice a shadow or plant-care question connected with the setting.
Thursday	C067, C068	Invite original art or a sound choice for the developing story.
Friday	C069, C070	Review how the space works and hear a voluntary family perspective.

What the educator prepares

Check the linked activity’s materials, safety, care needs and access. Keep familiar choices available and confirm that the purpose connects with a real interest. For infants, an invitation happens only during a comfortable awake opportunity; care and rest determine the day.

What to record

One actual action or communication; the adult support; the child’s response; and a possible next opportunity. Do not record an offered invitation as a completed skill.

How the week can change

Continue a worthwhile idea across several days. A child may choose another activity or another way to participate. Review the family’s perspective and what helped access before adding difficulty.

A week designing a useful play space

Pre-K · 4 years · 48–59 months

This is an illustrative menu of possible invitations, not five compulsory daily lessons. Repeat familiar work, omit unsuitable ideas and change the plan after observing. Every day still includes responsive care, movement, communication, relationships and choice.

Day	Library IDs	Possible invitation
Monday	C071, C081	Plan willing roles and begin a child-designed construction.
Tuesday	C077, C078	Compare needed quantities or explore a meaningful repeat.
Wednesday	C079, C074	Test one safe change and make a message for an actual audience.
Thursday	C083, C076	Map a route or adapt a movement game so more children can join.
Friday	C084, C072	Ask whether the contribution helped and revisit a useful support.

What the educator prepares

Check the linked activity’s materials, safety, care needs and access. Keep familiar choices available and confirm that the purpose connects with a real interest. For infants, an invitation happens only during a comfortable awake opportunity; care and rest determine the day.

What to record

One actual action or communication; the adult support; the child’s response; and a possible next opportunity. Do not record an offered invitation as a completed skill.

How the week can change

Continue a worthwhile idea across several days. A child may choose another activity or another way to participate. Review the family’s perspective and what helped access before adding difficulty.

A week of collaborative making

Kindergarten bridge · 5- and 6-year-olds · 60–83 months

This is an illustrative menu of possible invitations, not five compulsory daily lessons. Repeat familiar work, omit unsuitable ideas and change the plan after observing. Every day still includes responsive care, movement, communication, relationships and choice.

Day	Library IDs	Possible invitation
Monday	C085, C089	Choose a real purpose, accessible roles and a safe tool sequence.
Tuesday	C092, C091	Measure or represent a useful joining/separating problem.
Wednesday	C093, C088	Run a small safe comparison and communicate an actual finding.
Thursday	C095, C096	Develop an original work or a sound/movement sequence.
Friday	C097, C098	Hear different perspectives and select work/supports for reflection.

What the educator prepares

Check the linked activity’s materials, safety, care needs and access. Keep familiar choices available and confirm that the purpose connects with a real interest. For infants, an invitation happens only during a comfortable awake opportunity; care and rest determine the day.

What to record

One actual action or communication; the adult support; the child’s response; and a possible next opportunity. Do not record an offered invitation as a completed skill.

How the week can change

Continue a worthwhile idea across several days. A child may choose another activity or another way to participate. Review the family’s perspective and what helped access before adding difficulty.

Observe learning without turning play into a test

Record	Example	Avoid
Action and context	“Matched one cup to each person, then counted after a reminder.”	“Mastered number.”
Infant interaction	“Turned away; adult paused; infant looked back.”	“Poor attention.”
A change in strategy	“Widened the base after the tower fell.”	“Very smart.”
Communication and access	“Used a picture choice to request another turn.”	Treating speech as the only evidence.
Support	“Adult steadied the container once.”	Calling supported participation a failure.
Next opportunity	“Keep the same setup and observe the chosen strategy again.”	A fixed age-based deadline to complete it.

Look across time, relationships and contexts. An independent action in one event is not permanent mastery, and independence is not an infant performance goal. A declined invitation or a blank record does not show inability.

Use curriculum notes to improve teaching. Developmental concerns follow the approved family/referral process; these activities do not diagnose or replace validated screening. Keep health, safeguarding and required operational records in their proper systems.

Include every child and family

Access is part of the plan

Offer home languages, signs, augmentative communication, extra processing time, adapted grips, accessible positioning, quieter choices or another sensory route. Preserve the meaningful purpose while changing how a child can participate.

Participation is not compliance

Do not require eye contact, touch, tasting, public speech, a performance, a standard body position or the same finished product. Stop harm and provide supervision without making care, belonging or help conditional on a child’s response.

Families provide knowledge, not homework

Share a factual strength and ask what the family notices. Invite an optional familiar word, story or routine without purchases or disclosure of private circumstances. A family does not represent an entire culture.

Transitions remain supportive

For a move to another room or school, share strengths, the child’s voice, family perspective and useful supports with authorization. Toileting, mobility, speech or disability-related independence are not admission/readiness tests in this curriculum.

Privacy

Use secure approved communication and storage. The companion browser tool is local to one device and has no shared staff accounts or cloud synchronization. Export backups and protect child records.

A practical quality check

Ask…	Look for…
Do children have real agency?	They can choose, repeat, change direction, watch or decline without losing belonging or necessary care.
Is the adult intentional?	The educator can name a useful purpose and describe how the support fitted the actual child.
Is play sustained?	Familiar materials and work in progress stay available when practical; the day is not constant rotation.
Is care responsive?	Feeding, sleep, comfort, hygiene and individual plans take priority.
Is learning broad?	Relationships, language, movement, thinking, inquiry, expression and belonging all have meaningful opportunities.
Is access planned?	Communication, sensory, movement, cultural and family needs inform materials and interaction.
Does evidence change teaching?	Factual notes lead to a useful next opportunity rather than a score or a completion quota.

Start with a manageable selection, review with trained staff and families, and adapt after a short pilot. The 98 activities are a starting library, not a complete list of what children must learn or do.

Play invitation planner

Child / group; date; educator; age pathway

What actual interest, family perspective or observation prompted this?

One useful purpose and an open-ended setup

Materials, safety/care review and access supports

How I might join, model, respond or step back

What happened; support used; possible next invitation

Play observation record

Child / identifier; date; context; educator

What did the child actually do, communicate or change?

What did the adult do? What access/support was used?

How did the child respond? What meaning did the child give?

A working question or possible next opportunity · separate from facts

A dated record supports teaching decisions. It does not diagnose, rank children or certify permanent mastery.